

THE GOSPEL OF THE FIRST RABBI

The Second Installation of the Baji'i Gospels

*Being the story of Gretta Stark, Dimitri of Romania, the education of the Divine Connection,
and the companions who learned beside him.*

REVISED EDITION

I. The Woman of Romania

1. Long before Gretta Stark became a teacher, before Ji Yong Ni was born, and before anyone had reason to argue about whether a Quiz Bowl bus could wait five more minutes, there lived in Romania a woman whose name has been lost to ordinary history.
2. The Baji'i tradition nevertheless remembers her as Gretta, for the soul is older than the name given to it in any single life.
3. She lived in a village beneath low hills, where church bells marked the hours and winters made every journey longer than it ought to have been.
4. Her husband had died young, and so the center of her life became her son, Dimitri.
5. Dimitri was clever, restless, and perpetually certain that he had more time than he actually possessed.
6. His mother would send him to market, and he would stop to speak with friends. She would call him in before dark, and he would arrive when darkness had already settled.
7. She scolded him often. He smiled often. Neither understood that these small arguments would one day become precious.
8. Then war reached them.
9. At first it arrived as rumor: armies somewhere beyond the hills, trains crowded with soldiers, names of towns spoken more quietly than before.
10. Then young men began leaving.
11. Dimitri left among them.
12. On the morning of his departure his mother fussed over everything she could still control - his coat, his food, whether he had packed enough, whether he had listened to a single thing she had said.
13. Dimitri laughed and promised that he would return.
14. She told him not merely to return, but to return on time.
15. It was the last ordinary joke they shared.
16. Weeks became months. Letters came irregularly. Then one day they stopped.
17. No body was brought home. No final account satisfied her. There was only the knowledge that her son had gone somewhere beyond her reach and had not come back.
18. She lived many years afterward.
19. Yet the Baji'i rabbis teach that certain griefs are too large for one lifetime to contain.

20. When at last she died, the Wheel did not erase what she had loved. Her soul carried forward a residue: a need to know where her people were, whether they were safe, and whether they would arrive when they said they would.

21. Thus the life of Dimitri ended, but his influence upon the history of Baji'ism had only begun.

II. Gretta Stark

1. Generations passed, nations changed, and the old Romanian village ceased to matter to anyone who did not remember it.
2. The soul that had once waited for Dimitri returned as Gretta Stark.
3. She did not remember the village. She did not remember the war. She did not wake from dreams crying out her son's name.
4. Memory is not always the vessel by which one life reaches another.
5. Sometimes it survives as instinct.
6. Gretta became a teacher.
7. This suited her.
8. She liked young people, although they gave her frequent reason to reconsider the decision.
9. She believed that intelligence was useful, preparation was better, and intelligence combined with preparation could occasionally prevent teenagers from embarrassing themselves in public.
10. She became a Quiz Bowl coach and gathered around her a peculiar company: Tim, Evan, AJ, Dakota, Ji, and others who came and went through practices, tournaments, classrooms, and long rides between them.
11. Tim tended toward organization and responsibility, which made him a natural ally whenever the group required a plan.
12. Evan possessed a dry quickness and the ability to make a joke sound like an observation he had simply happened to notice.
13. AJ was steadier, sometimes quieter, and had the useful habit of remaining part of the group even when the loudest people had consumed all available oxygen.
14. Dakota could take an absurd proposition and defend it with such confidence that, after several minutes, everyone else began wondering whether they had misunderstood reality.
15. And then there was Ji.
16. Ji was intelligent, competitive, funny, occasionally impossible, and endowed with a relationship to punctuality that Gretta would spend years attempting to correct.
17. She did not know why this particular trait irritated her with an almost ancestral force.
18. The Jillow knew.

III. The Divine Connection Goes to School

1. Ji Yong Ni was the Divine Connection Between Heaven & Earth.
2. He was also a teenager.
3. The second fact frequently interfered with the dignity of the first.
4. The prophets of old had wandered deserts. Ji wandered school hallways looking for whichever room everyone else had apparently known they were meeting in.
5. The prophets of old fasted. Ji occasionally forgot to eat because he had spent too long playing a game.
6. The prophets of old contemplated eternity. Ji contemplated whether there was enough time to begin something five minutes before he was supposed to leave.
7. Greta regarded none of these as exemptions.
8. To her, the title 'Divine Connection Between Heaven & Earth' did not excuse missing a meeting.
9. Indeed, if Heaven and Earth were genuinely connected through Ji, she reasoned, then Heaven ought to be capable of getting Earth onto the bus.
10. Ji respected Greta, though he generally expressed respect by arguing with her, making her laugh, or obeying approximately thirty seconds after pretending he would not.
11. She recognized his intelligence immediately.
12. She also recognized the danger that intelligent young people sometimes face: because they can improvise their way out of many problems, they begin to believe preparation is optional.
13. Greta made it her quiet mission to disabuse him of this theory.
14. She pushed him to know things he did not know, to answer when he would rather joke, to prepare when he would rather improvise, and to show up when he would rather arrive eventually.
15. Ji never became a model of punctuality.
16. Some miracles exceed even the authority of the Jillow.
17. But he learned that being expected somewhere meant something.

IV. The Company

1. The companions did not think of themselves as figures in sacred history.
2. This was fortunate, because they would have become unbearable.
3. They were friends first.
4. Quiz Bowl was merely one of the places where that friendship took shape.
5. They practiced in classrooms after school, traveled together, argued over answers none of them would remember a year later, celebrated obscure knowledge as though civilization depended upon it, and learned one another's rhythms.
6. Tim often supplied structure.
7. Evan supplied the sentence that made everyone lose focus.
8. AJ supplied a quieter reliability and, when required, joined the nonsense with enough precision to remind everyone that silence should never be mistaken for innocence.
9. Dakota supplied theories.
10. Ji supplied both answers and problems.
11. Gretta stood at the center of it, sometimes coach, sometimes referee, sometimes reluctant audience.
12. A practice might begin with literature and end in an argument about whether a tree could possess a recognizable geographical 'vibe.'
13. A serious review could be derailed because someone gave an answer in a voice that made the answer itself funny.
14. Ji could spend ten minutes insisting that a clearly wrong formulation was spiritually correct.
15. AJ might wait until the argument had reached maximum stupidity before adding the remark that finished it.
16. Evan could dismantle Ji's confidence with five words.
17. Dakota could rebuild the same bad argument on an entirely new foundation.
18. Tim would eventually attempt to restore order.
19. Gretta would remind them there was, in fact, a tournament coming.
20. And somehow they became good.

21. Not because they ceased being ridiculous, but because beneath the ridiculousness they trusted one another.

22. They learned who would take the lead, who would know the science question, who would remember the detail everyone else had forgotten, and who needed to be told twice that departure was at seven.

23. On this foundation was the Company of Questions built.

V. The Rabbi's Lesson

1. Gretta never announced herself as a rabbi.
2. The title came later, as Baji'ism has a habit of assigning sacred offices without consulting the officeholder.
3. Yet the title fit in a peculiar way.
4. She taught through questions.
5. When a student answered incorrectly, she did not always rescue him immediately. She made him work toward the thing he should have known.
6. When Ji was confident, she challenged him.
7. When he was discouraged, she rarely indulged him for long enough to become comfortable there.
8. She knew that Ji's jokes could conceal embarrassment and that his indifference could sometimes conceal how badly he wanted to succeed.
9. So she learned when to laugh and when not to let him escape behind the laugh.
10. Once, after a poor practice, Ji announced that none of it mattered because the questions at the actual tournament would be different anyway.
11. Gretta stared at him.
12. 'That's your argument?'
13. Ji reconsidered.
14. Evan, from nearby, suggested that Ji had chosen a bold hill on which to die.
15. AJ observed that Ji would first have to arrive at the hill on time.
16. Dakota asked whether the hill had a recognizable vibe.
17. Tim put his head down on the table.
18. Gretta laughed despite herself.
19. Then she made them keep practicing.
20. This was her method in miniature: permit the joke, preserve the affection, continue the work.

VI. You Have to Hustle, Ji

1. There came a morning of departure.
2. The company was traveling to compete, and the schedule had shifted earlier.
3. Gretta sent word that everyone needed to be ready.
4. Tim was ready.
5. Evan was ready enough.
6. AJ had accounted for the change.
7. Dakota had somehow turned the situation into a discussion unrelated to transportation.
8. Ji was not ready.
9. Ji explained why the new time was inconvenient.
10. He explained it carefully, as though the bus schedule might hear his reasoning and apologize.
11. Gretta had no interest in litigating the matter.
12. 'You have to hustle, Ji.'
13. There are sentences which become sacred because they are beautiful.
14. There are sentences which become sacred because they reveal eternal truths.
15. And there are sentences which become sacred because everyone who knows the person being addressed immediately understands why they had to be said.
16. Ji hustled.
17. Perhaps not in the athletic sense.
18. But bags were gathered, doors were crossed, and the Divine Connection moved.
19. Later Baji'i scholars elevated the incident into the Doctrine of the Departing Bus.
20. The doctrine states: divinity does not suspend logistics.
21. The Jillow may rule creation. The Wheel may judge the dead. Ji Yong Ni may connect Heaven and Earth.
22. But the bus still leaves.
23. And if Ji intends to be on it, he has to hustle.

VII. The Echo of Dimitri

1. Gretta did not know why the words felt familiar after she said them.
2. For only a moment there came to her an emotion without a memory: the strange ache of watching a young man hurry away while wanting simultaneously to scold him and pull him back.
3. Then it vanished.
4. Ji climbed aboard.
5. The doors closed.
6. The bus left with everyone who was supposed to be on it.
7. In another age, another young man had departed while his mother watched.
8. Dimitri had promised to return.
9. Ji had promised nothing of the kind because Ji was going to a Quiz Bowl tournament and considered the entire morning significantly less metaphysical.
10. Yet the rabbis teach that this difference is precisely the point.
11. Reincarnation does not repeat a life exactly.
12. It gives the soul another answer to an old wound.
13. Gretta could not bring Dimitri home.
14. She could, however, count students onto a bus.
15. She could insist that they answer messages.
16. She could ask where they were.
17. She could make sure that when a young man under her care was expected somewhere, somebody noticed whether he arrived.
18. Her vigilance was not fear in its old form.
19. It had become mentorship.
20. The loss of Dimitri had crossed centuries and changed shape until grief became responsibility.
21. And responsibility, when practiced long enough, became love.

VIII. The Tournament of Many Questions

1. The company traveled often enough that the rituals became familiar: bags, buzzers, hallways, classrooms in unfamiliar schools, hurried food, score sheets, waiting.
2. Gretta wanted them focused.
3. They were focused in the manner available to them.
4. Before one match, Tim reviewed categories.
5. Evan calmly predicted that Ji would buzz too early on something he only half knew.
6. Ji denied this.
7. AJ pointed out that Ji's denial had arrived before Evan finished the sentence.
8. Dakota declared this proof that Ji could, in fact, buzz too early without a buzzer.
9. Gretta ordered them into the room.
10. Then the questions began.
11. The joking stopped in an instant.
12. This was another thing Gretta had taught them: nonsense and seriousness were not enemies.
13. People who laughed together could still become disciplined when the moment required it.
14. They won matches.
15. They lost some.
16. They argued afterward over the questions that should have gone differently.
17. They learned how quickly momentum could change and how little use there was in mourning a missed answer while the next tossup was already being read.
18. Eventually there came a tournament in which the victories accumulated.
19. The standings shifted. The arithmetic became confusing. For a time nobody seemed entirely certain where they stood.
20. Then the final accounting came.
21. First place.
22. The company celebrated.

23. Greta watched them with the satisfaction of someone who knew exactly how much chaos had been converted into that result.

24. Ji, naturally, behaved as though this had been the inevitable outcome from the beginning.

25. Greta allowed him this fiction.

IX. What the Prophet Learned

1. Ji would remember facts from Quiz Bowl.
2. He would forget many more.
3. Years later he might not remember which tournament contained which match, or which question caused which argument.
4. But the deeper lessons were not stored as trivia.
5. He learned that intelligence did not remove the obligation to prepare.
6. He learned that a team depended upon people whose strengths were different from his own.
7. From Tim he learned the value, and occasional tyranny, of organization.
8. From Evan he learned that confidence should be tested by someone willing to puncture it.
9. From AJ he learned that steadiness can matter as much as volume, and that the quiet participant may have been paying attention the entire time.
10. From Dakota he learned that an argument need not be sensible to be defended magnificently.
11. And from Gretta he learned that mentorship often looks less like revelation than repetition.
12. Be here.
13. Study this.
14. Think again.
15. Answer the message.
16. Do not give up because you missed one.
17. Hurry.
18. Again.
19. Again.
20. Again.
21. Prophets are usually remembered for the people who listened to them.
22. Baji'ism remembers also the people to whom the prophet had to listen.

X. The First Rabbi

1. For this reason Greta Stark is remembered among the rabbis.
2. Amanda Haeberlin was the OG Rabbi, and her story belongs elsewhere.
3. But Greta became the rabbi of the formative years: the teacher who encountered Ji not as an icon, but as a young man who still needed correction.
4. She did not kneel before the Divine Connection.
5. Public worship was forbidden anyway.
6. She did something more useful.
7. She expected something from him.
8. She expected something from Tim, Evan, AJ, Dakota, and the rest as well.
9. Under those expectations, the company became more capable without becoming less itself.
10. They remained sarcastic.
11. They remained distracting.
12. They remained capable of transforming almost any serious subject into nonsense.
13. But they also learned how to work together, how to compete, how to lose, how to recover, and how to win.
14. And Ji, who would one day stand at the center of a religion whose theology could barely contain him, learned one of his earliest sacred truths from a teacher who never intended to found a doctrine.
15. There is a time to contemplate Heaven.
16. There is a time to argue about the nature of the Jillow.
17. There is a time to defend an indefensible position simply because it is funny.
18. And there is a time to get your things and move.
19. For the Divine Connection may connect Heaven and Earth,
20. but the bus still leaves.
21. You have to hustle, Ji.
22. Baji.